

BOHEMIA RF4 COMBAT SYSTEMS SYNTHESIS

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BOHEMIA_RF4_DANGER_SCHOOL_MASTER.md (83 captured screens)

This is ANALYSIS. Nothing here is Bohemia canon.
Nothing here is a direction

call. Every Bohemia-facing question is marked
[PENDING, Paolo's call].

0. THE ONE SENTENCE

Rogue Fable IV is not a damage game. It is a POSITION game with a damage readout, and almost every system in it exists to make geometry more powerful than statistics.

Once you see that, all 83 tips collapse into about nine machines.

1. ACTION ECONOMY: THE FREE-MOVEMENT BUDGET

This is the foundation everything else stands on.

The base rule. One action per turn. Attacking ends your turn. Moving ends your turn. Waiting is a legal action and is frequently the correct one.

The exception that makes the game. Speed Points. Sprinting moves you WITHOUT ending your turn. That means SP is not movement, it is a currency that buys free actions outside the turn economy entirely.

The regen rule is the sharp part. SP regenerates on every 5th global game turn, on a fixed world clock. It is NOT a per-use cooldown that starts when you spend. Spend on turn 4 and

it refunds on turn 5, one turn later, for free.

That single design choice does a huge amount of work:

- It rewards clock-reading, not hoarding. A player who knows the parity spends aggressively right before the tick. A player who does not know it hoards and plays worse.
- It creates a rhythm to the whole fight. The fight has a heartbeat, and skilled play means acting on the beat.
- It converts a resource system into a timing system. Same resource, completely different skill being tested.

Design principle extracted: a resource on a GLOBAL clock tests timing. The same resource on a PER-USE cooldown tests only patience. The global clock is strictly the more interesting choice and costs nothing extra to implement.

Bohemia relevance: Bohemia already runs a global 120 BPM clock where BEAT=0.5s and movement quantizes to it, and running is two cells per beat. The architecture for a globally-ticking resource already exists. What does not exist is a free-action budget that lets you move without spending your combat action. [PENDING, Paolo's call] whether Bohemia gets an SP equivalent at all.

2. THE KITE LOOP: THE ACTUAL CORE VERB

Strip the tips down and the intended fight shape is a loop, not an exchange:

1. Engage, dump your abilities
2. Abilities go on cooldown, you are now weak
3. Disengage using SP, terrain, and line of sight
4. Kite until cooldowns recharge
5. Re-engage

The game says outright that you will often need to kite around a level to let abilities recharge, and that a single speed point is enough to kite almost indefinitely.

Why this is smart. In most turn RPGs, running out of resources means you lose. Here, running out of resources means the fight enters a different PHASE. Retreat is not failure, retreat is a move. That converts "I am out of cooldowns" from a death sentence into a puzzle.

The cost of it. It only works if the level is big enough and connected enough to run laps in. Kiting is a level-design dependency, not just a combat rule. A cramped room deletes the entire core verb. The game clearly knows this, which is why so many tips are about corridors, corners, and pillars.

Design principle extracted: if your combat loop requires retreat, your level generator has a hard obligation to guarantee retreat is possible. Combat design and map generation are the same system wearing two hats.

3. MOVEMENT ASYMMETRY: HOW DISTANCE IS MANUFACTURED

Kiting cannot work if the enemy moves as well as you do. So the game builds in asymmetries you can exploit.

- **Diagonal versus orthogonal.** Slow enemies can only move orthogonally. You can move diagonally. Every diagonal step you take costs them more than it costs you. You are literally generating distance out of pure geometry, with no resource spent.
- **Slow speed exploitation.** You can use an enemy's slow diagonal movement to open a three tile gap specifically to bait a charge ability.
- **Liquids.** Water blocks sprinting, fast movement, and movement abilities. This is terrain that switches OFF the free-movement budget. You use SP on land, then put water between you and the pursuit. Terrain that disables the most powerful system in the game is enormously strong, and it cuts both ways.
- **Flight and levitation.** A traversal state on its own countdown, tracked separately from the potion duration that grants the stat. Two different numbers that players are explicitly warned not to confuse. Slightly clumsy, but it means flight is a windowed resource, not a mode.

Design principle extracted: movement asymmetry is a cleaner difficulty lever than stat inflation. Making an enemy orthogonal-only is more interesting than giving it more HP, and it teaches the player something durable.

4. VISION IS THE MASTER SWITCH

This is the highest leverage system in the entire game and it is not presented as one system. It is scattered across a dozen tips. Pull them together and the architecture is obvious.

Line of sight gates, at minimum:

- Ranged enemies cannot shoot without vision of the player
- Shamans need vision of BOTH the player and the ally to place a totem
- Summoners need vision to call allies
- Healers only heal enemies they can see
- Aggroed enemies only shout to alert others if the player is in vision
- Enemies never spot a sprinting player at all

So a single wall simultaneously disables ranged damage, enemy buffing, enemy reinforcement, enemy healing, and aggro propagation. One variable, five systems.

And then the game lets you MANUFACTURE walls. This is the part worth stealing conceptually:

- Fire plus water makes steam clouds that block vision
- A sleep bomb blocks line of sight, and a sleeping body plugs a corridor
- Cloud walls get summoned behind the player, so your own positioning determines where the wall lands

Portable, craftable, positional line of sight turns a static level property into an active player ability. The map stops being a fixed board and becomes editable mid-fight.

Design principle extracted: pick ONE variable that as many enemy systems as possible depend on. Then give the player tools to control that variable. You get combinatorial depth without writing combinatorial content.

Bohemia relevance: Bohemia's cover system and the pop-out-of-cover behavior in the Dead Eye Dial already put line of sight at the center of the combat read. The open note about cover popping being spammable in 1v1 is a vision-gating question wearing a different hat. [PENDING, Paolo's call] whether enemy support behaviors in Bohemia get gated on vision the way RF4 gates them.

5. AWARENESS AND AGGRO: A THREE LAYER MACHINE

Not one stealth stat. Three separate layers, each with its own rule.

Layer 1, detection radius. Base 6 tiles, reduced by 1 per point of stealth. Displayed on the map as rings. Legible, countable, plannable.

Layer 2, awareness state. An unaware enemy showing one question mark will NEVER spot you. Showing three question marks, it has a chance to. Two distinct states with two distinct rules, communicated with a single glyph count.

Layer 3, alert propagation. When an enemy aggro's it has a 50% chance to shout immediately. It only shouts if the player is in vision. Other enemies only respond to a shout within 10 tiles.

Stack those three and you get real infiltration play out of very little code:

- Aggro one enemy at maximum range and the shout cannot reach the pack, so you peel one target off a group
- If the coin flip comes up no-shout, you can retreat out of vision with SP and the alert never propagates at all
- Sprinting is a hard immunity to being spotted, so the free-movement budget is ALSO the stealth budget, which means one resource is doing double duty
- Even 1 point of stealth stops sleeping enemies from waking, so the player chooses when the fight starts by removing the stealth item on purpose

That last one is the sharpest. Stealth is normally a defensive stat. Here it is a trigger switch. You take your armor off to start a fight on your terms.

Design principle extracted: a binary spotted/unspotted stealth system has no decisions in it. Split detection, awareness, and propagation into three separate rules and the same fiction produces a genuine tactical language.

6. TERRAIN AS THE PRIMARY WEAPON

The environment is not decoration and it is not a modifier. It is the strongest damage source in the game, and it deliberately does not scale off your stats.

- **Unstable terrain.** Characters on it take 50% more physical damage. The tip explicitly frames it as a two-part play, avoid standing on it yourself while leading enemies onto it. Same tile, opposite meaning depending on who is on it.
- **Pits.** Knocking an enemy into a pit instantly kills it, framed openly as the answer to high HP tanks. An enemy charging into a pit dies instantly too. This is a total bypass of the damage system.
- **Walls.** Lunging enemies take damage from hitting a wall, and you can bait the lunge by standing in line when the cooldown resets.

- **Traps.** Kite enemies through them.
- **Cursed floor.** Heals undead enemies. Terrain that is advantageous for THEM, which means terrain reading is mandatory, not optional.
- **Corpse denial.** Destroying skeleton bodies with terrain prevents resurrection, and simply standing on a skeleton prevents it too. The floor itself becomes contested space after the kill.

Why the pit rule matters so much. It means power level and solvability are decoupled. A weak character with good positioning can kill a tank. That is the single most important property in a roguelite, because it means a bad item run is not automatically a dead run. Skill has somewhere to go when the numbers do not show up.

Design principle extracted: guarantee at least one kill channel that ignores the player's damage stat entirely. It is the difference between a roguelite that respects skill and one that just checks your loot.

Bohemia relevance: Bohemia's KILL zone already deals exactly 100 damage through the armor stat rather than flagging an instakill, which is a deliberately different philosophy from a pit. Worth noting the contrast rather than resolving it. [PENDING, Paolo's call] whether Bohemia ever wants a true stat-independent environmental kill, or whether the dial is meant to be the only kill channel in the game.

7. PUBLISHED DETERMINISM: THE AI IS AN OPEN BOOK

This is the most unusual choice in the whole corpus and the one most worth thinking hard about.

RF4 tells the player its own AI rules and its own exploits, plainly:

- Enemies attack in a fixed order, left to right, top to bottom, closest first, producing the hit order W, N, S, E, NW, SW, NE, SE
- Most ranged enemies have a 25% chance to retreat if you are within three tiles
- Channeled abilities leave the enemy vulnerable for a turn
- Enemy pathing routes around summoned bombs toward clear paths, which can be used to steer them and can also backfire and trap you
- Turrets fire in one direction at a time, so zigzagging forces them to turn and SP gets you a free hit
- A summoned firestorm expands and damages its own caster if you stay close behind

terrain

- Spawned enemies award no XP, and a spawner gives the same XP whether it dies from damage or from exhausting its spawns

And then it teaches the attack order ENVIRONMENTALLY. The gladiators in the tutorial attack in that exact sequence so you can watch it, and the blood spatter around the practice dummy is arranged in the same pattern so the floor itself is a diagram. The tip then asks you to notice, rather than telling you to memorize.

What this buys. Mastery becomes knowledge rather than execution. The skill ceiling rises without the input demands rising at all. A player who has read the board can beat a fight that a faster player cannot. That is a very specific audience promise, and it is completely compatible with a slow turn-based game on a phone.

What it costs. Nothing can be surprising twice. Every deterministic rule is a rule the player eventually stops thinking about. Determinism buys depth on first contact and spends it over time. Games that go this route must keep adding new deterministic rules, because the old ones become free.

Design principle extracted: deterministic AI plus published rules equals a game about knowledge. Hidden AI plus randomness equals a game about adaptation. These are opposite promises and a game has to pick one. RF4 picked knowledge and never wavers.

8. DAMAGE MATH: BOUNDED VARIANCE AND VISIBLE BREAKPOINTS

Damage rolls between 50% and 100% of the listed value. A 20 damage weapon deals 10 to 20.

The tip then does the player's arithmetic for them: 10 HP enemies always die in one hit, most 20 HP enemies need two.

That is the entire point of the 50% floor. Because the roll cannot go below half, the player can plan against the WORST case instead of the average. Kill counts become knowable rather than hopeful. Randomness is preserved for texture, but it never invalidates a plan.

Crits stack across sources. Sleeping and unstable both grant critical hits on physical damage, and crits from different sources stack. Two stacked crits kill in one hit. So the crit system is not a damage bonus, it is a combo system. Two positional setups multiply into a breakpoint you could not otherwise reach.

Design principle extracted: put a floor under damage variance. Unbounded low rolls do

not create tension, they create unplannable turns, and the player correctly responds by disengaging from planning entirely.

9. STATUS EFFECTS ARE POSITION CONTROL, NOT DAMAGE

Almost nothing in the status list is about dealing damage. It is all about denying the enemy its turn or reshaping the board.

Sleep bomb, one item, at least five jobs:

- Blocks line of sight, preventing enemy attacks outright
- Plugs a corridor with a sleeping body so you can shoot the rest with clear aim
- Cancels berserk, so timing it AFTER the enemy berserks strips the buff
- Blocks cloud attacks if placed before the enemy attacks
- Sleeping enemies release constricting effects, so it is also a cleanse

Knockback: prevents enemy actions entirely while you deal damage. The recommended loop is wait for cooldowns, knock back to deny actions, damage, re-sleep, repeat. Enemy turn denial as the primary defensive stat.

Corners: when an enemy follows you around a corner it creates the room you need to knock it back and land an AOE strike without taking damage. The corner is not cover, the corner is a spacing tool.

Design principle extracted: one item with five geometry-dependent uses beats five items with one use each. It rewards understanding over inventory, and it costs a fraction of the content budget.

10. THE ECONOMY OF RESETS

A quietly deep system with a genuinely unusual centerpiece.

- Energy shroom restores SP and MP and resets ALL ability cooldowns
- Healing shroom restores HP and cures physical ailments
- Food restores 50% of HP, MP and SP, explicitly recommended mid-fight
- Shrooms can be destroyed by shooting them, so the reset resource is destructible and therefore contestable

And then the big one. Leveling up restores all cooldowns. Investing a talent point restores a cooldown. An amnesia potion can be used to forget a talent and refresh the cooldown twice.

That means LEVELING UP IS A COMBAT ABILITY. Progression and combat are the same system. A held level up is a full reset you can detonate at the worst moment of a fight. Combined with the spawner XP rule, you can deliberately time two spawner deaths so the level ups land mid-fight and carry you through the remaining enemies.

That is a progression system with a tactical trigger on it, which is rare and very strong.

Against it: the corpus also states plainly that it is better to use consumables early than to die with a full inventory. The game knows its players hoard and tells them not to. Worth noting that a tip is not a fix. If players hoard, the system is teaching hoarding somewhere, and text does not undo that.

11. TARGET PRIORITY DOCTRINE

The game repeatedly teaches “kill the cause, not the symptom.”

- Kill the totem, do not fight through the buff
- Kill the spawner, the adds are worth no XP anyway
- Break the healer’s sight instead of out-damaging the heal
- Prioritize the back line, use SP to get line of sight, burst them down

Every one of those is the same lesson with a different skin, which is exactly how a lesson should be taught. Repetition across contexts, not repetition of words.

12. HOW THE GAME TEACHES, WHICH IS ITS OWN SYSTEM

Three distinct teaching registers in the corpus, and the split is deliberate.

Register A, explicit mechanical instruction. Bulleted, numeric, states keys and percentages. Used for anything the player could not possibly derive: the SP regen parity, the 50 to 100% damage band, the 6 tile detection radius, the 10 tile shout range, the 25% ranged retreat chance.

Register B, the riddle line. A single unbulleted poetic sentence with no mechanical vocabulary at all. Not all paths to destruction are direct. The right angle can make all the difference. Even hunters grow weary of the hunt. These appear where the room itself is the puzzle. They point at a solution without naming it, so the player still gets the discovery.

Register C, environmental demonstration. The gladiator drill and the blood spatter teaching the attack order. No text at all, and it is the most memorable teaching moment in the entire set.

The escalation is the design. Register A for what is unguessable, Register B for what is guessable, Register C for what is showable. Most games use only A. RF4 grades the register to the thing being taught.

Design principle extracted, and this is the one I would fight for: the teaching register should be chosen by whether the player COULD derive the rule unaided. Tell them what they cannot derive. Hint at what they could. Show them what the room can demonstrate. Never explain something the floor could have shown.

13. WHAT I WOULD PUSH BACK ON

Not everything here is worth taking, and a teardown that only praises is useless.

The tip volume itself. 83 screens of instruction is a lot of reading placed between the player and the game. Some of it is doing work the fiction should have done. When a tip has to say do not click the pit tiles, use numpad, graphics slightly broken, the tip has become a bug report with a border around it.

Duplicate and near-duplicate tips. The sprint tip appears twice with only close distance versus create distance changed. The auto-explore tip appears twice identically. Cheap to fix, and the repetition trains players to skip boxes, which then costs you the tips that actually mattered.

A real contradiction the game creates for itself. One tip says base SP regeneration is 1 SP every 5 turns, which reads as a personal per-use timer. A later tip corrects this to a global every-5th-turn clock and explicitly says it is not 5 turns after use. Those are two different systems, and the player learns the wrong one first. If a rule is subtle enough to need a correction later, state it correctly the first time.

Determinism has a shelf life. Covered above. Published fixed rules are enormously satisfying to learn and then become invisible. This is a real cost, not a nitpick, and it is the main structural risk in the whole approach.

14. THE NINE MACHINES, COMPRESSED

For quick reference. This is the whole corpus reduced to its load-bearing parts.

1. A free-movement currency on a global clock, which makes timing the skill
 2. A retreat-and-recharge combat loop, which makes level shape a combat system
 3. Movement asymmetry, which makes geometry generate distance for free
 4. Vision as one variable gating five enemy systems, plus tools to manufacture it
 5. Three-layer awareness, which turns stealth into a fight-start trigger
 6. Terrain kills that ignore your damage stat, which keeps bad runs solvable
 7. Published deterministic AI, which makes mastery knowledge instead of execution
 8. Bounded damage variance, which makes breakpoints plannable
 9. Status effects as turn denial and board editing, one item doing five jobs
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15. OPEN FORKS FOR BOHEMIA

Listed, not decided. Every one of these is a direction call.

- [PENDING, Paolo's call] Does Bohemia get a free-movement budget in the SP sense, a resource that buys motion without spending the combat action? The 120 BPM global clock is already the right substrate for it if so.
- [PENDING, Paolo's call] Are enemy support behaviors gated on line of sight? This connects directly to the noted 1v1 cover-pop spam issue.
- [PENDING, Paolo's call] Published deterministic enemy behavior versus hidden and adaptive. This is the deepest fork in the document and it decides what kind of mastery Bohemia rewards.
- [PENDING, Paolo's call] Does Bohemia want any kill channel that bypasses the damage system the way a pit does, given that the KILL zone currently deals 100 through armor rather than flagging an instakill?
- [PENDING, Paolo's call] Is there a stealth or awareness layer at all, and if so does it use the three-layer split.
- [PENDING, Paolo's call] Teaching register policy. Whether Bohemia adopts the A/B/C split by derivability, and how that interacts with the standing rule that the infrastructure is the curriculum.

MULTI-ENEMY DIAL, DIRECT HIT ON A KNOWN OPEN FORK. RF4's fixed attack resolution order, closest first then W, N, S, E, NW, SW, NE, SE, is a working answer to the

multi-enemy dial question that has been open in Bohemia, namely rotating wedge versus per-target wedge with tab versus positional cone. A deterministic published resolution order would mean the player always knows which enemy acts next and can therefore choose which one to dial. That is a fourth option that was not previously on the list. Not adopting it, just putting it on the table.

Given that the resolution order is now a live option, do you want the player to always know which enemy fires next, or is not knowing part of the pressure?